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**DEPARTMENT OF STATISTICS**



**M.Sc. QUANTITATIVE FINANCE**  
**MSQF 535: GLOBAL FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT**  
**EMPIRICAL REPORT**  
**EMPIRICAL ANALYSIS OF SWISS**  
**FOREIGN DIRECT INVESTMENT**  
**(2015–2024)**

**COURSE INSTRUCTOR**

**Dr. Venkatajalapathy**

Department of Statistics

**SUBMITTED BY**

**N Rohit Vedhanandh**

**Reg. No.: 25MSQUFPY0002**

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Executive Summary

Switzerland occupies a disproportionately large position in global finance, consistently ranking among the world’s top ten direct investment economies. This monograph investigates the structural trends, determinants, and macroeconomic spillovers of Swiss direct investment over the decade **2015–2024**, utilizing official **Swiss National Bank (SNB)** datasets.

Core Empirical Takeaways (2015–2024)

- **Structural Capital Export Asymmetry:** Outward FDI stock (CHF 1,340.1 billion, 167.5% GDP) exceeded inward FDI stock (CHF 925.7 billion, 115.7% GDP) by CHF 414.4 billion in 2024, confirming Switzerland’s enduring net capital exporter role.
- **Post-2017 Inward Contraction:** Inward FDI contracted by 31.3% from its 2017 peak (CHF 1,347.8 billion) to CHF 925.7 billion in 2024, driven by OECD BEPS compliance, corporate tax reform (STAF/TRAF 2020), and Franc valuation deflation.
- **Phantom Conduit Distortion Unmasked:** While the Netherlands (26.4%) and Luxembourg (15.2%) lead immediate statistics, Ultimate Beneficial Owner (UBO) tracing unmasks the **United States as the dominant investor**, controlling 40.0% (CHF 370.7 billion) of inward FDI.
- **Sectoral Asymmetry & Global Labor Multiplier:** Inward FDI is skewed toward services (77.6%), while outward FDI anchors high-value manufacturing (37.9%, led by life sciences). Swiss MNEs operate 21,265 foreign affiliates employing 2.48 million personnel abroad (4.43× domestic parent employment).

## 1 Introduction

Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) constitutes the most stable and structurally transformative component of cross-border capital flows. Unlike liquid portfolio investments or volatile bank credits, direct investments embody long-term managerial control, operational integration, and international knowledge diffusion. The Swiss Confederation represents a preeminent case study in global finance: despite accounting for under 0.1% of the world's population, Switzerland consistently ranks among the top global direct investment hubs.

### 1.1 Meaning and Importance of FDI

#### Definition 1.1: Foreign Direct Investment (IMF & OECD Standard)

According to the IMF BPM6 and OECD Benchmark Definition (4<sup>th</sup> Ed.), **Foreign Direct Investment** is established when a resident entity in one economy acquires at least 10% of the **voting power** in an enterprise resident in another economy, reflecting a lasting interest and significant managerial influence.

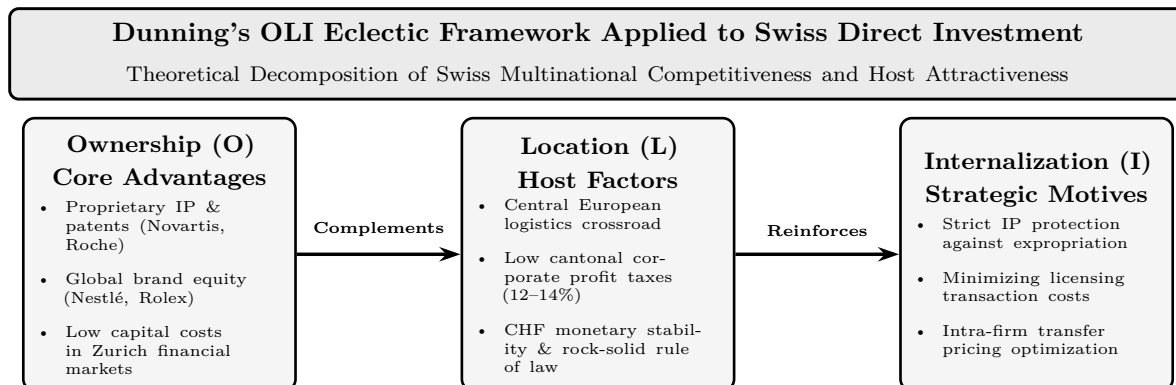
FDI comprises three distinct accounting instruments: **equity capital**, **reinvested earnings**, and **intra-company debt**. It drives economic expansion through five primary channels: (1) *Capital Formation* (financing productive capacity without sovereign debt); (2) *Technology Diffusion* (cross-border transmission of proprietary R&D); (3) *Employment Generation* (high-wage technical and managerial jobs); (4) *Trade Integration* (complementing intra-firm export corridors); and (5) *Productivity Discipline* (intensifying domestic competitive efficiency).

### 1.2 Inward versus Outward FDI

**Inward FDI** measures capital deployed by foreign enterprises into the domestic economy, reflecting national host attractiveness. **Outward FDI** captures capital invested abroad by domestic multinational enterprises (MNEs), reflecting the global competitiveness of home corporations. In 2024, Switzerland's outward FDI stock (CHF 1,340.1 billion) exceeded its inward stock (CHF 925.7 billion) by CHF 414.4 billion, solidifying its enduring status as a **structural net capital exporter**.

### 1.3 Why Switzerland is an Attractive FDI Destination

Switzerland's investment attractiveness is anchored in eight structural pillars: (1) *Institutional Stability* (predictable direct democracy and fiscal discipline); (2) *Strategic Central European Hub* (dense logistics and EU connectivity); (3) *Premier Talent Pool* (world-class STEM universities: ETH Zurich, EPFL); (4) *Competitive Corporate Taxation* (cantonal effective tax rates of 11.8–14%); (5) *Global Financial Center* (deep liquidity and sophisticated wealth management in Zurich/Geneva); (6) *Innovation Ecosystem* (consistently ranked #1 in the Global Innovation Index); (7) *Currency Stability* (safe-haven Franc shielding assets); and (8) *Quality of Life* (attracting top international executive talent).



**Figure 1:** Dunning's Eclectic Paradigm (OLI Framework) Contextualized for the Swiss Direct Investment Ecosystem. Symmetrical pillars illustrate the simultaneous ownership advantages of Swiss MNEs and location advantages of the Swiss host economy.

2 Overview of FDI in Switzerland

A thorough empirical assessment requires distinguishing between **capital stocks** (cumulative valuation of foreign assets at year-end) and **capital transactions (flows)**, which record net cross-border financial movements during the calendar year.

2.1 FDI Capital Stocks (2024 Year-End Position)

According to official Swiss National Bank statistics, Switzerland maintained an inward FDI capital stock of **CHF 925.7 billion** and an outward FDI capital stock of **CHF 1,340.1 billion** in 2024 (Table 1).

Table 1: Consolidated Foreign Direct Investment Capital Stocks and Flows in Switzerland (2024)

| Direction                   | Equity (CHF bn) | Debt (CHF bn) | Total Stock | Equity Share | 2024 Flow |
|-----------------------------|-----------------|---------------|-------------|--------------|-----------|
| Inward FDI (in Switzerland) | 886.7           | 39.0          | 925.7       | 95.8%        | -83.4     |
| Outward FDI (Swiss Abroad)  | 1,303.0         | 37.2          | 1,340.1     | 97.2%        | -11.1     |
| Net Direct Investment Gap   | +416.3          | -1.8          | +414.4      | —            | +72.3     |

Source: Swiss National Bank (SNB). Positive net investment gap denotes net capital export position.

Both inward and outward stocks are overwhelmingly dominated by **equity capital** (95.8% and 97.2%), demonstrating that Swiss MNEs and foreign subsidiaries rely on substantial core capitalization and retained earnings rather than volatile debt instruments.

2.2 FDI Capital Transactions (Flows) in 2024

In 2024, direct investment flows recorded net disinvestments across both directions: **CHF – 83.4 billion** for inward transactions and **CHF – 11.1 billion** for outward transactions.

Deconstructing the 2024 Net Outflows

The negative inward transaction flow (CHF – 83.4 billion) reflects three structural dynamics rather than a loss of underlying competitiveness: (1) *Monetary Normalization*: The SNB’s exit from negative rates (from –0.75% to positive territory) and surging global yields prompted multinational corporate treasuries to relocate cash surpluses to high-yielding dollar markets; (2) *Earnings Repatriation*: US parent corporations repatriated European earnings to cover domestic US financing costs; and (3) *OECD BEPS Restructuring*: The introduction of Pillar Two minimum tax (15%) catalyzed the consolidation and balance sheet downsizing of non-operational Swiss Special Purpose Entities (SPEs).

Proposition 2.1: Balance of Payments Stock-Flow Accumulation Identity

Direct investment capital stock evolves according to the dynamic balance of payments valuation identity:

$$\text{Stock}_t = \text{Stock}_{t-1} + \text{Flow}_t + \Delta\text{Valuation}_t^{\text{FX}} + \Delta\text{Valuation}_t^{\text{Price}} + \text{Other Adjustments}_t \quad (1)$$

where  $\Delta\text{Valuation}_t^{\text{FX}}$  denotes currency translation adjustments (Franc appreciation deflates foreign currency asset values), and  $\Delta\text{Valuation}_t^{\text{Price}}$  captures equity price revaluations.

3 Trend Analysis: 2015–2024

The decade from 2015 to 2024 witnessed historic structural shifts: the unpegging of the Franc in January 2015, the COVID-19 pandemic shock, the implementation of corporate tax reforms, and subsequent global monetary tightening.

### 3.1 Long-Term Evolution of Inward and Outward Capital Stocks

Table 2 synthesizes the annual trajectories of inward and outward direct investment capital stocks, delineating Switzerland's permanent net capital export surplus.

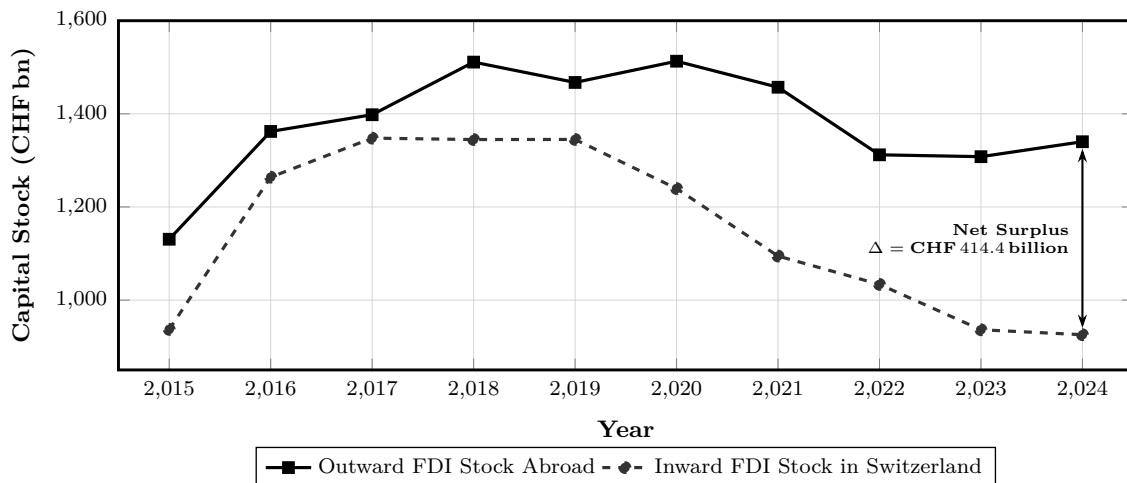
**Table 2:** Evolution of Swiss Inward and Outward FDI Capital Stocks (2015–2024)

| Year                             | Inward (CHF bn) | Inward $\Delta$         | Outward (CHF bn) | Outward $\Delta$   | Net Surplus    |
|----------------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------|------------------|--------------------|----------------|
| 2015                             | 937.1           | —                       | 1,130.7          | —                  | +193.6         |
| 2016                             | 1,264.0         | +34.9%                  | 1,362.2          | +20.5%             | +98.2          |
| 2017                             | 1,347.8         | +6.6%                   | 1,398.1          | +2.6%              | +50.3          |
| 2018                             | 1,344.8         | -0.2%                   | 1,511.1          | +8.1%              | +166.3         |
| 2019                             | 1,345.0         | +0.0%                   | 1,467.4          | -2.9%              | +122.4         |
| 2020                             | 1,239.5         | -7.8%                   | 1,513.0          | +3.1%              | +273.5         |
| 2021                             | 1,094.6         | -11.7%                  | 1,457.1          | -3.7%              | +362.5         |
| 2022                             | 1,033.7         | -5.6%                   | 1,312.0          | -10.0%             | +278.3         |
| 2023                             | 936.3           | -9.4%                   | 1,308.0          | -0.3%              | +371.7         |
| 2024                             | 925.7           | -1.1%                   | 1,340.1          | +2.5%              | +414.4         |
| <b>10-Yr <math>\Delta</math></b> | <b>-1.2%</b>    | <b>-31.3% from peak</b> | <b>+18.5%</b>    | <b>Stable high</b> | <b>+114.0%</b> |

Source: Swiss National Bank (SNB). Figures in billions of Swiss Francs (CHF bn). Net Surplus = Outward minus Inward stock.

#### Key Empirical Observations:

- **Inward Contraction from 2017 Peak:** After peaking at CHF 1,347.8 billion in 2017, inward FDI stock underwent a cumulative contraction of 31.3 % to CHF 925.7 billion in 2024, reflecting BEPS compliance, corporate restructurings, and currency translation deflation.
- **Outward Resilience and Rebound:** Outward FDI peaked at CHF 1,513.0 billion in 2020. Despite a mark-to-market correction in 2022, outward stock rebounded by +2.5 % in 2024 to CHF 1,340.1 billion, demonstrating persistent overseas commitment.
- **Expanding Net Surplus:** The net direct investment surplus widened from +CHF 193.6 billion in 2015 to an all-time peak of **+CHF 414.4 billion in 2024** (+114 %), cementing Swiss net creditor strength.



**Figure 2:** Comparative Evolution of Swiss Inward vs. Outward Direct Investment Capital Stocks (2015–2024). Source: SNB. The persistent positive spread reflects Switzerland's structural capital exporter status.

### 3.2 FDI Integration as Percentage of GDP

With Switzerland's nominal GDP at approximately **CHF 800 billion** in 2024, direct investment intensity ratios reach:

$$\Phi^{\text{Inward}} = \frac{\text{CHF 925.7 billion}}{\text{CHF 800.0 billion}} \approx 115.7\%, \quad \Phi^{\text{Outward}} = \frac{\text{CHF 1,340.1 billion}}{\text{CHF 800.0 billion}} \approx 167.5\% \quad (2)$$

These ratios vastly exceed average OECD benchmarks (40–55%), confirming Switzerland’s position among the world’s most hyper-globalized economies.

#### 4 Sector-wise FDI Analysis

Decomposing direct investment capital stocks by economic activity uncovers a stark structural contrast: Switzerland functions predominantly as a specialized commercial, trading, and holding platform for inward investors, whereas Swiss outward direct investment maintains an exceptionally robust advanced manufacturing core.

##### 4.1 Cross-Directional Sectoral Comparison

Table 3 consolidates the sectoral composition of inward versus outward direct investment capital stocks in 2024.

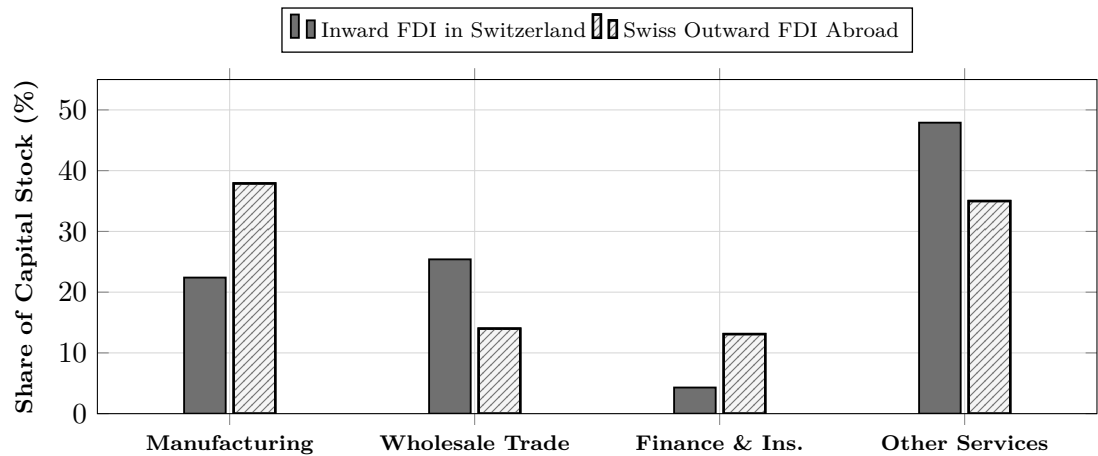
**Table 3:** Sectoral Composition of Swiss Inward and Outward FDI Capital Stocks (2024)

| Economic Sector / Activity            | Inward (CHF mn) | Share (%)     | Outward (CHF mn) | Share (%)     |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------|---------------|------------------|---------------|
| Chemicals and Plastics                | 109,860         | 11.9%         | 190,217          | 14.2%         |
| Electronics, Energy, Optical          | 52,679          | 5.7%          | 86,864           | 6.5%          |
| Metals and Machinery                  | 24,894          | 2.7%          | 61,249           | 4.6%          |
| Other Manufacturing                   | 20,338          | 2.2%          | 169,670          | 12.7%         |
| <b>Total Manufacturing</b>            | <b>207,770</b>  | <b>22.4%</b>  | <b>507,999</b>   | <b>37.9%</b>  |
| Trade (Wholesale & Commodity)         | 235,172         | 25.4%         | 187,146          | 14.0%         |
| Other Services (Holding & Management) | 443,374         | 47.9%         | 469,537          | 35.0%         |
| Other Services (General)              | 52,294          | 5.6%          | 31,513           | 2.4%          |
| Commercial Banks                      | 21,326          | 2.3%          | 65,649           | 4.9%          |
| Insurance Companies                   | 18,068          | 2.0%          | 109,810          | 8.2%          |
| <b>Total Services</b>                 | <b>717,940</b>  | <b>77.6%</b>  | <b>832,142</b>   | <b>62.1%</b>  |
| <b>Total All Sectors</b>              | <b>925,711</b>  | <b>100.0%</b> | <b>1,340,141</b> | <b>100.0%</b> |

*Source: Swiss National Bank (SNB). Direct investment capital stocks at year-end 2024.*

#### Key Comparative Insights:

- **Tertiary Dominance in Inward FDI (77.6 %):** Inward capital is concentrated in **Wholesale Trade** (CHF 235.2 billion, 25.4 %)—anchored by commodity hubs in Geneva and Zug—and corporate holding entities (47.9 %).
- **Manufacturing in Outward FDI (37.9 %):** Swiss MNEs deploy CHF 508.0 billion into foreign manufacturing, reflecting competitiveness in life sciences, food processing (Nestlé), and electrical automation (ABB).



**Figure 3:** Sectoral Distribution of Swiss Inward vs. Outward Direct Investment (2024). Source: SNB. Illustrates the services skew for inward FDI versus high manufacturing intensity for outward FDI.

4.2 Pharmaceutical and Chemical Sector Deep Dive

The pharmaceutical, biotechnical, and specialty chemical cluster represents Switzerland’s most dynamic direct investment vertical:

- **Inward Expansion:** Inward stock surged from CHF 63.7 billion in 2015 to CHF 109.9 billion in 2024 (+72.5 % **growth**), driven by foreign biopharma leaders establishing European clinical formulation hubs.
- **Outward Strength:** Swiss outward investment reached CHF 190.2 billion in 2024 (14.2 % of total outward stock), driven by strategic cross-border acquisitions of foreign biotechnology startups.

Case Vignette 4.1: The Basel Life-Sciences Triad: Roche and Novartis

**Novartis AG** and **F. Hoffmann-La Roche AG** deploy tens of billions in global R&D. By acquiring foreign oncology platforms (e.g., Genentech, AveXis), they secure foreign patent assets while anchoring fundamental chemical synthesis in Basel.

5 Country-wise FDI Analysis

Evaluating bilateral geographic allocations requires distinguishing between the **Immediate Investor** (direct creditor jurisdiction) and the **Ultimate Beneficial Owner (UBO)**, which identifies the ultimate controlling corporate parent.

5.1 Major Inward Investors: Immediate versus Ultimate Origin

Tracing capital ownership through immediate versus UBO lenses reveals the classic “**Phantom FDI**” conduit distortion (Table 4).

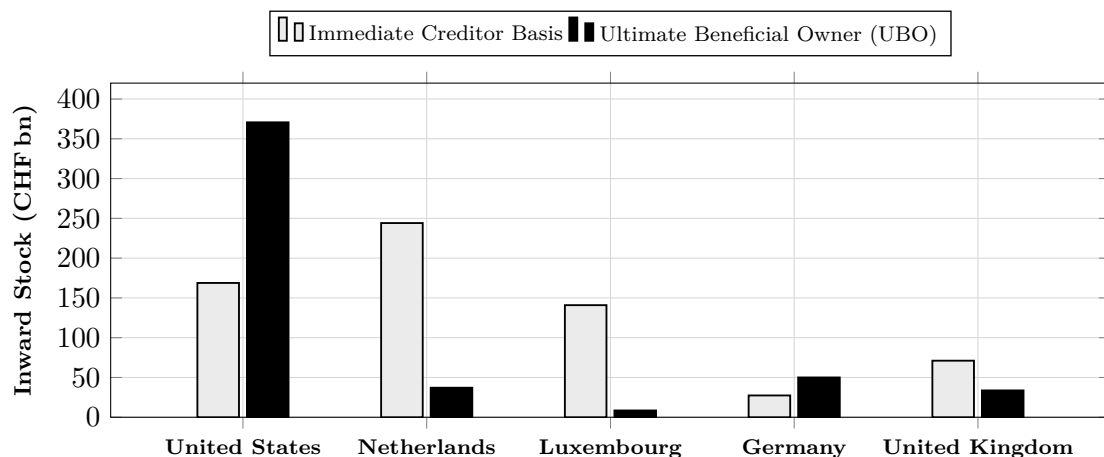
**Table 4:** Inward FDI Capital Stocks by Immediate Investor vs. Ultimate Beneficial Owner (2024)

| Rank | Country        | Imm. (CHF mn) | Imm. % | UBO (CHF mn) | UBO % | Intermediation Role                    |
|------|----------------|---------------|--------|--------------|-------|----------------------------------------|
| 1    | United States  | 168,833       | 18.2%  | 370,695      | 40.0% | True Dominant Origin (+120% unmasked)  |
| 2    | Netherlands    | 244,052       | 26.4%  | 37,107       | 4.0%  | Primary European Conduit (-85% drop)   |
| 3    | Luxembourg     | 140,873       | 15.2%  | 8,500        | 0.9%  | Pass-Through SIV Vehicle (-94% drop)   |
| 4    | Germany        | 27,403        | 3.0%   | 49,969       | 5.4%  | Direct Industrial Core (+82% increase) |
| 5    | United Kingdom | 71,091        | 7.7%   | 33,701       | 3.6%  | Concentrated Financial Partner         |
| 6    | Belgium        | 34,794        | 3.8%   | 38,075       | 4.1%  | Stable Operating Footprint             |
| 7    | Japan          | 36,780        | 4.0%   | 36,000       | 3.9%  | Direct Technology Investment           |
| 8    | France         | 17,435        | 1.9%   | 20,100       | 2.2%  | Cross-Border Retail & Luxury           |

Source: Swiss National Bank (SNB). Direct investment capital stocks at year-end 2024.

#### Unmasking the American Capital Preponderance

While the Netherlands (26.4%) and Luxembourg (15.2%) appear as the largest immediate creditor nations, their share collapses by over 85% under UBO accounting. Conversely, the **United States surges from 18.2% to 40.0% (CHF 370.7 billion)**, demonstrating that American multinationals heavily route European investments through Benelux Special Purpose Entities (SPEs) prior to deployment into Switzerland.



**Figure 4:** Immediate vs. UBO Inward Direct Investment Capital Stocks (2024). Source: SNB. Graphically unmasks the phantom conduit distortion where US parent capital is routed via Benelux holding structures.

## 5.2 Major Destinations of Swiss Outward FDI

Swiss outward direct investment is strategically allocated across North America (26.2%), Europe (53.0%), and high-growth Asian hubs (11.9%), as detailed in Table 5.



**Table 5:** Top Destination Countries and Regional Allocation of Swiss Outward FDI (2024)

| Top Partner Country       | Stock (CHF mn) | Share        | Geographic Region            | Stock (CHF mn)   | Share         |
|---------------------------|----------------|--------------|------------------------------|------------------|---------------|
| 1. United States          | 334,702        | 25.0%        | Europe (EU & EFTA)           | 710,935          | 53.0%         |
| 2. Netherlands            | 160,480        | 12.0%        | North America (USA & Canada) | 351,484          | 26.2%         |
| 3. Germany                | 81,654         | 6.1%         | Asia                         | 159,694          | 11.9%         |
| 4. Luxembourg             | 74,769         | 5.6%         | Central & South America      | 99,567           | 7.4%          |
| 5. United Kingdom         | 73,146         | 5.5%         | Africa                       | 9,711            | 0.7%          |
| 6. France                 | 64,413         | 4.8%         | Oceania                      | 8,750            | 0.7%          |
| <b>Top 6 Destinations</b> | <b>789,164</b> | <b>59.0%</b> | <b>Total Worldwide Stock</b> | <b>1,340,141</b> | <b>100.0%</b> |

Source: Swiss National Bank (SNB). Outward direct investment capital stocks at year-end 2024.

## 6 Swiss Multinational Enterprises Abroad

The operational reach of Swiss multinationals is captured by non-financial indicators: the expansion of foreign operating affiliates and the scale of personnel employed across international subsidiaries.

### 6.1 Operational Expansion of Swiss MNEs (2015–2024)

Table 6 tracks the synchronous expansion of foreign subsidiary entities and global affiliate headcounts over the decade.

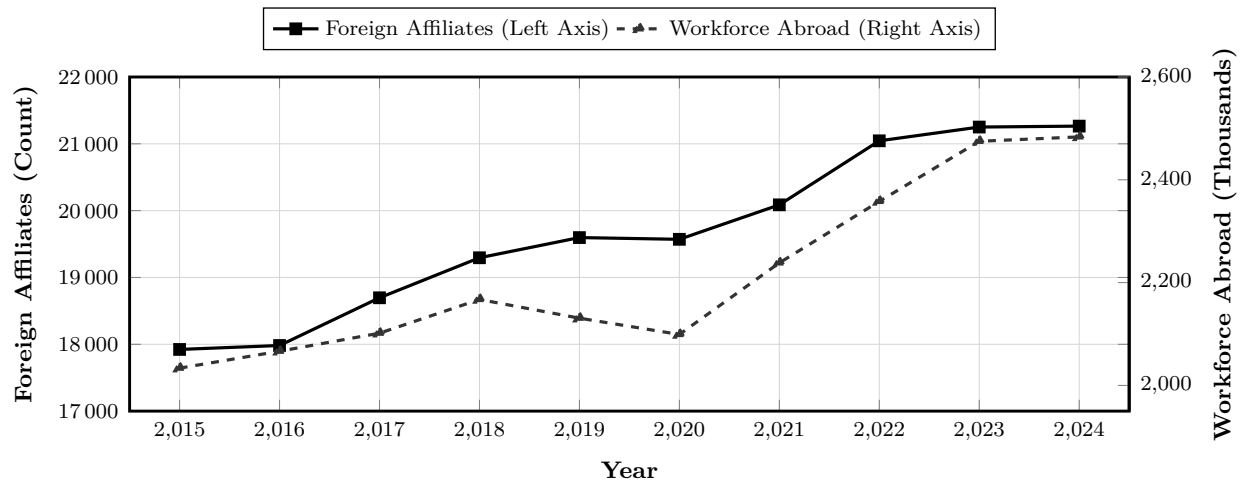
**Table 6:** Operational Trajectory of Non-Resident Subsidiaries of Swiss MNEs (2015–2024)

| Year           | Affiliates    | Growth                 | Staff (k)     | Growth              | Staff/Affiliate |
|----------------|---------------|------------------------|---------------|---------------------|-----------------|
| 2015           | 17,923        | —                      | 2,033.6       | —                   | 113.5           |
| 2016           | 17,982        | +0.3%                  | 2,066.5       | +1.6%               | 114.9           |
| 2017           | 18,696        | +4.0%                  | 2,101.6       | +1.7%               | 112.4           |
| 2018           | 19,295        | +3.2%                  | 2,167.2       | +3.1%               | 112.3           |
| 2019           | 19,597        | +1.6%                  | 2,130.8       | -1.7%               | 108.7           |
| 2020           | 19,571        | -0.1%                  | 2,099.1       | -1.5%               | 107.3           |
| 2021           | 20,087        | +2.6%                  | 2,238.4       | +6.6%               | 111.4           |
| 2022           | 21,045        | +4.8%                  | 2,358.0       | +5.3%               | 112.0           |
| 2023           | 21,251        | +1.0%                  | 2,474.9       | +5.0%               | 116.5           |
| 2024           | 21,265        | +0.1%                  | 2,483.5       | +0.3%               | 116.8           |
| <b>10-Yr Δ</b> | <b>+18.7%</b> | <b>+3,342 entities</b> | <b>+22.1%</b> | <b>+449.9k jobs</b> | <b>+2.9%</b>    |

Source: Swiss National Bank (SNB). Staff employed in non-resident enterprises controlled by Swiss MNEs.

#### The 4.43× Global Labor Multiplier

In 2024, Swiss MNEs employed **2,483,500 people abroad** across 21,265 subsidiaries. Compared to the 560,964 domestic personnel employed by Swiss parent companies in Switzerland, Swiss enterprise sustains an **overseas-to-domestic labor multiplier of 4.43×**. For every employee at a corporate headquarters in Switzerland, Swiss MNEs support more than four workers in global manufacturing, clinical trials, and distribution worldwide.



**Figure 5:** Synchronous Expansion of Swiss MNE Foreign Subsidiaries and Global Affiliate Employment (2015–2024). Source: SNB. Both indicators display robust structural growth over the decade.

## 6.2 Geographic Distribution and Value Chain Governance

The regional dispersion of the 21,265 foreign subsidiaries in 2024 comprises: **Europe:** 12,892 (60.6 %); **Asia:** 3,184 (15.0 %); **North America:** 2,443 (11.5 %); **Central/South America:** 1,497 (7.0 %); **Africa:** 834 (3.9 %); and **Oceania:** 415 (2.0 %).

### Case Vignette 6.1: Nestlé's Decentralized Value Chain Governance

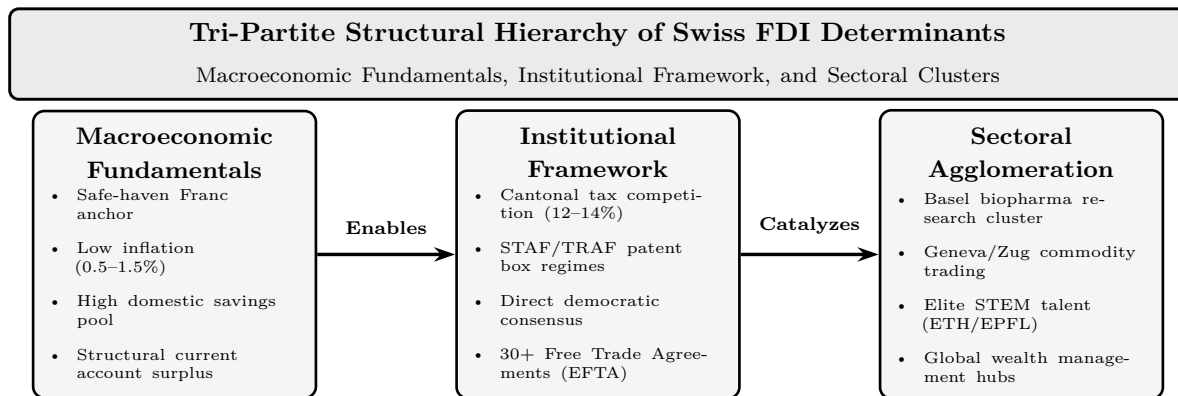
**Nestlé S.A.** operates over 340 production factories across 77 nations, decentralizing packaging and local sourcing while concentrating fundamental nutritional R&D and global trademark ownership at its Swiss parent headquarters in Vevey.

## 7 Determinants of FDI in Switzerland

Direct investment in Switzerland is not driven by classical market-seeking motives, given Switzerland's small domestic consumer market ( $\approx 9$  million residents). Instead, investment dynamics are governed by a tri-partite hierarchy of macroeconomic fundamentals, institutional governance, and sector-specific agglomeration economies.

### 7.1 Macroeconomic, Institutional, and Sectoral Drivers

- **Macroeconomic Stability:** Switzerland maintains low inflation (averaging 0.5–1.5%), insulating capital against real depreciation. While Swiss Franc appreciation deflates foreign currency asset values, it imposes continuous non-price quality discipline on Swiss industry.
- **Tax Federalism & the 2020 STAF/TRAF Reform:** Swiss corporate taxation combines federal and cantonal rates, yielding competitive effective profit tax rates of 11.8 % to 14 % in cantons like Zug and Basel. The 2020 STAF/TRAF reform replaced ring-fenced regimes with OECD-compliant patent boxes and R&D super-deductions (up to 150%).
- **Sectoral Agglomeration:** Strict patent enforcement, world-class technical institutes (ETH Zurich, EPFL), and specialized trade finance in Geneva provide irreplaceable industry ecosystems.



**Figure 6:** Tri-Partite Hierarchy of Swiss Direct Investment Determinants. Symmetrical alignment highlights how macroeconomic stability and fiscal frameworks synergize to sustain world-leading innovation clusters.

## 8 Economic Impact of FDI

The interplay between foreign investment inside Switzerland and the overseas operations of Swiss multinationals stimulates domestic employment, accelerates gross capital formation, and amplifies total factor productivity.

### 8.1 Domestic Parent Employment and Macroeconomic Spillovers

In 2024, multinational parent entities directly employed 560,964 **persons** in Switzerland across high-wage headquarters, laboratories, and specialized production facilities (Table 7).

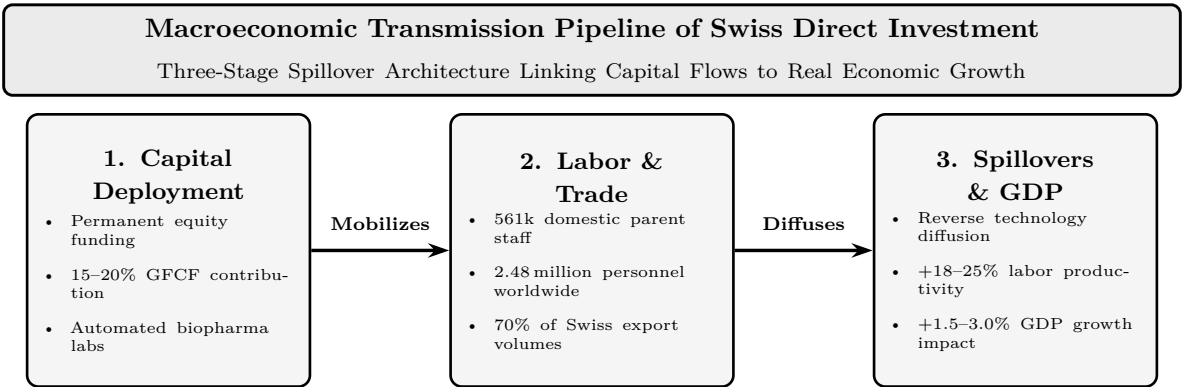
**Table 7:** Domestic Workforce of Swiss Multinational Parent Enterprises in Switzerland (2015–2024)

| Year                    | Manufacturing Staff | Services Staff | Total Parent Staff | Annual Change           |
|-------------------------|---------------------|----------------|--------------------|-------------------------|
| 2015                    | 212,773             | 315,671        | 528,444            | —                       |
| 2018                    | 218,440             | 326,950        | 545,390            | +1.3%                   |
| 2021                    | 218,620             | 331,100        | 549,720            | +0.7%                   |
| 2024                    | 222,556             | 338,408        | 560,964            | +0.4%                   |
| <b>Growth (2015–24)</b> | <b>+4.6%</b>        | <b>+7.2%</b>   | <b>+6.2%</b>       | <b>+32,520 Net Jobs</b> |

*Source: Swiss National Bank (SNB). Resident multinational parent enterprise headcounts in Switzerland.*

#### Core Spillover Channels:

- **Capital Formation:** Direct investment contributes an estimated 15 % to 20 % of annual Swiss Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF), directed heavily toward automated cleanrooms and IT infrastructure.
- **Trade Integration:** Multinational enterprises account for 70 % of total Swiss exports, utilizing global affiliate networks to distribute high-margin pharmaceuticals and precision machinery.
- **GDP Contribution:** Direct operational activities and knowledge spillovers contribute an estimated 1.5 % to 3.0 % to annual Swiss real GDP growth.



**Figure 7:** Macroeconomic Spillover Pipeline of Swiss Direct Investment. Symmetrical stages illustrate the progression from capital deployment to labor absorption and economy-wide GDP spillovers.

9 Major Findings

An empirical synthesis of the 2015–2024 Swiss National Bank datasets produces four core findings:

1. **Inward Contraction vs. Outward Resilience:** Inward FDI stock contracted by 31.3% from its 2017 peak (CHF 1,347.8 billion) to CHF 925.7 billion in 2024 due to international tax harmonization and corporate consolidations. Conversely, outward FDI remained robust, expanding +18.5% across the decade to CHF 1,340.1 billion.
2. **Expanding Net Creditor Surplus:** Switzerland’s net direct investment surplus widened to an all-time peak of +CHF 414.4 billion, affirming its structural status as a global capital exporter.
3. **Conduit Intermediation Unmasked:** While the Netherlands and Luxembourg appear as the top immediate sources (41.6% combined), Ultimate Beneficial Owner (UBO) tracing establishes that the **United States is the true dominant investor**, controlling 40.0% (CHF 370.7 billion) of inward FDI.
4. **Industrial Core vs. Services Skew:** Inward FDI is concentrated in services (77.6%), while outward FDI maintains an advanced manufacturing base (37.9%, or CHF 508 billion), led by the Basel life-sciences cluster.

**Table 8:** Consolidated Empirical Assessment Matrix: Direct Investment in Switzerland (2015–2024)

| Dimension          | Quantitative Baseline                      | Empirical Observation                           | Strategic Assessment            |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Inward Stock       | CHF 925.7 billion (115.7% GDP)             | −31.3% decline from 2017 peak                   | Consolidation of SPEs & BEPS    |
| Outward Stock      | CHF 1,340.1 billion (167.5% GDP)           | Rebounded +2.5% in 2024                         | High MNE competitiveness        |
| Net Balance        | +CHF 414.4 billion surplus                 | Outward exceeds inward by > 40%                 | Structural net capital exporter |
| Conduit Distortion | US UBO: 40.0% vs. Imm.: 18.2%              | NL/LU collapse by > 80% under UBO               | Treaty routing via Benelux      |
| Sectoral Core      | Inward: 77.6% Services; Outward: 37.9% Mfg | Pharma: CHF 110 billion in, CHF 190 billion out | Life sciences is premier anchor |
| Global Multiplier  | 2.48 million abroad vs. 561k domestic      | 4.43× global labor multiplier                   | Deep value chain integration    |
| GDP Impact         | +1.5% to +3.0% annually                    | Direct GFCF & knowledge spillovers              | Vital growth engine             |

Source: Author’s empirical synthesis based on SNB time-series data (2015–2024).

## 10 Conclusion and Strategic Outlook

Switzerland's foreign direct investment ecosystem demonstrates extraordinary scale and structural adaptability. The country serves simultaneously as a critical European host for advanced corporate management, life-sciences innovation, and commodity trading, and as a formidable global investor deploying over CHF 1.3 trillion worldwide.

### 10.1 Strategic SWOT Synthesis and Actionable Policy Imperatives

- **Core Strengths:** Consensual political stability; elite STEM universities (ETH/EPFL); world-leading biopharma and wealth clusters; and unmatched property rights protection.
- **Emerging Challenges:** Secular inward stock contraction (31.3% drop from peak); Franc appreciation cost pressures; and the OECD Pillar Two minimum tax (15%) narrowing cantonal differentials.
- **Growth Opportunities:** Frontier verticals (AI, quantum computing, personalized medicine); green and sustainable finance leadership; and accelerating direct investment integration with high-growth Asian hubs.

**Policy Recommendations:** (1) *Pillar Two Adaptation:* Reinvest QDMTT top-up revenues into direct R&D matching grants and clean energy subsidies; (2) *Finalize EU Bilateral III:* Secure permanent Single Market access for Swiss med-tech and industrial exporters; (3) *Expand Asian Free Trade:* Build upon the EFTA-India TEPA pact to broaden investment protection across Mercosur and ASEAN; (4) *Streamline Skilled Immigration:* Increase non-EU/EFTA work permit quotas for elite scientific talent; and (5) *Infrastructure Resilience:* Guarantee long-term low-carbon baseload electricity for automated data and bio-manufacturing facilities.

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